

Quarters and the Two-High Match Family: Cover 4, Cover 6, Palms

Two safeties who are deep defenders and run stoppers at the same time, the corner rules that make it work, the half-and-half and trap versions, and why the NFL turned to it after 2018.

Second-and-8 near midfield. The offense comes out with three wide receivers and a tight end, two receivers on each side. Before the snap the broadcast's high camera shows both safeties standing only about 9 or 10 yards deep, one over each slot receiver, and both cornerbacks backed off 7 or 8 yards. It looks soft. The offense hands the ball off on an inside run, and the first defender to hit the running back, four yards downfield, is one of those safeties, arriving at full speed from a spot that looked like pass coverage. Two plays later the offense fakes the same run and throws deep, and the same safety is running stride for stride with the tight end up the seam. How can one player be a deep pass defender and a run stopper on the same snap? And why did NFL defenses, which spent the 2010s crowding an eighth man into the box, spend the next six years taking him back out? The answer is a coverage with a misleading name: **quarters**.

You'll be able to...

- Diagram quarters (Cover 4) against a 2x2 formation and say each defender's rule, not just his zone: corners, safeties, the apex defenders and the linebackers.
- Explain how a quarters safety reads the inside receiver (#2) and turns into a man defender, a helper on the outside receiver, or a run defender, and why that read is the whole coverage.
- Tell the two cornerback rules apart, MOD and MEG, and say what each one buys and costs.
- Recognise Cover 6 (quarters on one half, Cover 2 on the other) and Palms (the trap) before and after the snap.
- Explain, with the data and its caveats, why two-high match coverage spread through the NFL between 2018 and 2025, and name the plays that attack it: light-box runs, the bootleg flood and the running back's wheel route.

i You'll need

This is a level 4 chapter. One line each on what it builds on:

- **Shells** (A First Look at Defense): a two-high shell has two safeties deep, one on each side of the middle; one-high has one safety in the deep middle. The box is the area near the ball where the run is defended, and a light box has no more defenders in it than the offense has blockers. A defender at an apex stands halfway between the last man in the box and a slot receiver, so he can play either.
- **Formations** (Spread Formations): 2x2 is two receivers on each side; 3x1 (trips) is three to one side. Receivers are numbered from the sideline in on each side: #1 is the widest, then #2, then #3.
- **Zones and matching** (Coverage Fundamentals): the deep field splits into thirds, halves or deep quarters (about 13 yards wide each). The flat is the short area near the sideline, the curl the intermediate area between the numbers and the hash, the hook the area inside it. Pattern matching is zone coverage whose defenders pick up receivers man-to-man by rule once the routes declare. A press corner lines up within a yard of his receiver; an off corner, 5 to 10 yards away. MOFO means middle of the field open (nobody in the deep middle); MOFC, closed.
- **Cover 3 match** (Cover 3): Cover 3 whose zone players match routes; the seam-flat defender takes #2 up the seam before he worries about the flat.
- **Cover 2** (Cover 2 and Tampa 2): two safeties each guard a deep half, five defenders play underneath, and the hard corner squats in the flat. Its weak spots are the sideline behind the corner and the deep middle between the safeties. 2-Man is two deep with man underneath.
- **Run fits** (Run Fits and Box Math): the force defender turns a run back inside; the alley player fills the lane between the force and the box; the plus-one is the one more run defender than the offense has blockers. A defender reads blockers' "hats": a blocker firing out low means run, one popping up tall to protect means pass.
- **Routes and concepts** (Passing Fundamentals, Dropback Concepts): a seam runs straight upfield between the hash and the numbers; an out breaks flat toward the sideline; a slant breaks sharply inside after a step or two; a dig breaks flat inside at 10 to 15 yards; a corner route breaks toward the back pylon; a wheel starts toward the flat and turns up the sideline. Four verticals sends four receivers deep; a flood puts three receivers at three depths on one side.
- **Play-action** (Play-Action, Boots and Screens): play-action fakes a run before a pass; on a bootleg the quarterback fakes one way and rolls out the other.
- **Who's who:** on offense X is the receiver on the line, Z the receiver off it, Y the tight end and H the third receiver, usually in the slot. On defense the Mike and Will are the two linebackers in a nickel defense, and the nickel back is the fifth defensive back.

Reading the diagrams: offense is blue circles (Q quarterback, R running back, C center). Defense is outlined squares: E and T defensive ends and tackles, M the Mike, W the Will, \$ the nickel back, CB a cornerback, FS and SS the free and strong safety. A **green ring** marks the players to watch. The faint lines across the field are 5 yards apart from the line of scrimmage (the blue line), and the small numbers on the left edge give the depth; the short ticks are the hash marks. Solid arrows are offensive routes, dashed orange arrows defenders' movements, the dotted brown arrow a pass.

Quarters in one picture: four deep, but not really

Start with the name, because it misleads almost everyone. **Quarters**, also called **Cover 4**, is a two-high coverage in which four defenders, the two cornerbacks and the two safeties, each start with a deep quarter of the field, a lane about 13 yards wide. That much is in every coverage chart, and it's why the coverage is filed under "4" in the numbering system. If that were the whole story, quarters would be a very safe, very passive coverage: four defenders deep, only three left underneath, nothing thrown over anyone's head and plenty thrown in front of them.

But that isn't how quarters is played. Each of those four deep defenders has a *rule* that tells him whom to cover once the receivers start running, and two of those rules point the safeties forward, not back. Here is the alignment and the rules against the most common formation in the NFL, a 2x2 set with the tight end attached.

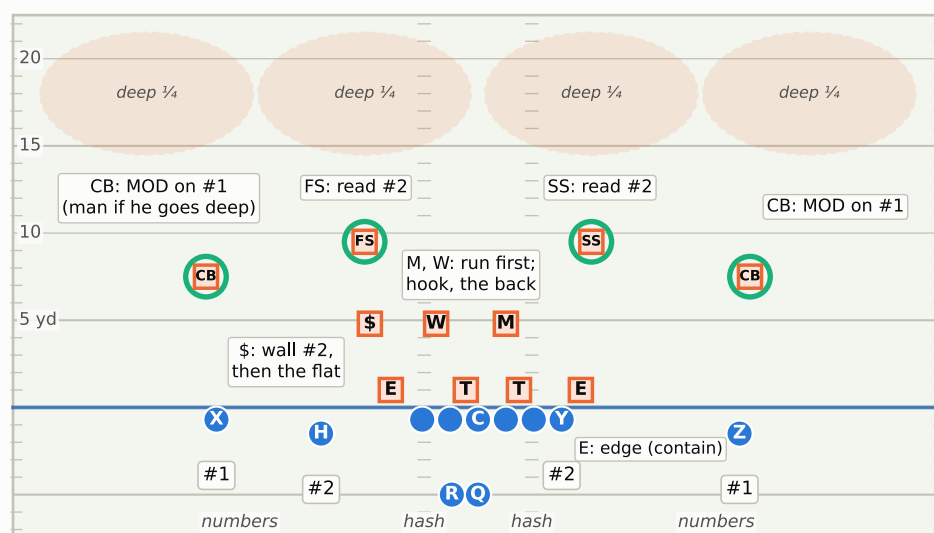


Figure 1: Quarters against a 2x2 formation (11 personnel, tight end attached on the right). The shaded ovals are the four deep quarters each defender starts with, but the labels are what matter: each defender's rule. The corners (CB) play MOD on the outside receiver, #1: man-to-man if he runs deep. The safeties (FS, SS) read the inside receiver on their side, #2: H on the left, the tight end Y on the right. The nickel (\$) at the apex walls off #2 and then takes the flat; the linebackers play the run first, then the hook zones and the running back; the strong-side end sets the edge outside the tight end. Notice how shallow the safeties are, about 9 or 10 yards, and how narrow: closer to the slot than to the numbers. Cover 2 safeties stand at 12 to 14 yards and wider.

Go around the picture one position at a time.

- **The corners** line up 7 or 8 yards off the outside receiver (#1), square or with a slight outside shade, eyes on him. Their rule, MOD, is the subject of a section below. The short version: if #1 runs deep, the corner has him man-to-man; if #1 runs a short route, the corner lets him go and drops into his deep quarter.
- **The safeties** are the heart of the coverage. They line up 8 to 10 yards deep (some teams 10 to 12), a few yards inside the slot receiver or tight end on their side. That's much shallower and narrower than a Cover 2 safety, who has to reach the sideline and so stands at 12 to 14 yards, outside the hash. The quarters safety doesn't have a sideline to reach. His landmark is a narrow inside lane, and his real job is to read the inside receiver.
- **The apex defenders**, here the nickel back on the left, stand between the tackle and the slot, 4 or 5 yards deep. Their first job against a pass is to *wall #2*: get in the slot receiver's path and keep him from running freely up the seam, so the safety behind has time to read him. Then they take the first receiver who comes to the flat.
- **The linebackers** read run first. Against a pass they drop to the hook zones and take the running back if he releases, the receiver some systems call #3 even when he's in the backfield.
- **The front** rushes four. The end outside the tight end is the edge (contain) player against runs to his side.

Count the defenders against the two receivers on one side. The corner, the safety, the apex defender and, a step inside, a linebacker: four players against two receivers, with the back as a possible third. Coaches like to say quarters is really "four over two" on each side, not four deep. Everyone deep is also, depending on what the receivers do, a man defender or a run defender. That is what makes quarters a pattern-matching coverage, and the purest one in common use.

i Madden vs. real life

In a video game's play menu, "Cover 4" usually draws four blue deep zones and three short ones, and the defenders drop to them like spot-drop zone players. If the real coverage worked that way it would be a prevent defense: four defenders guarding grass 15 yards deep while the offense completed everything underneath. Real quarters is a *read* coverage. The deep quarters are starting points; the receivers' first steps decide who covers whom, and the two safeties spend the first second of every snap deciding whether they are deep defenders at all. If you remember one thing from this chapter, make it this: **quarters safeties play the inside receiver, not a zone.**

! Why it exists

What it solves. A defense wants two things that normally conflict: two safeties deep, so the offense can't hit an explosive pass over the top, and an extra run defender, so it can't run the ball down its throat. Quarters gets both from the same two players. Standing at 9 or 10 yards instead of 13, a safety is close enough to the line to fit a run in time and deep enough to carry a receiver up the seam. And because every deep defender matches a receiver, four vertical routes meet four deep defenders (see the figure in the next section), which spot-drop Cover 3 can't say.

What it gives up. The shallow, inside-leaning safeties are reading, and anything that makes them read wrong hurts: a run fake that looks like a run, a receiver whose release looks like a block, a route that starts one way and ends another. With only three defenders underneath, the short outside throws (the quick out, the hitch, the flat) belong to the offense unless a corner or an apex defender takes them away. Quarters is a coverage that trades a few easy short completions for no deep ones, and asks its safeties to be right.

The read safety: one key, three answers

The quarters safety is the clearest example of a **read safety**: a safety whose job is decided after the snap by a single key receiver, usually #2 on his side. Coaches teach it as three answers to one question, *what did #2 do?*

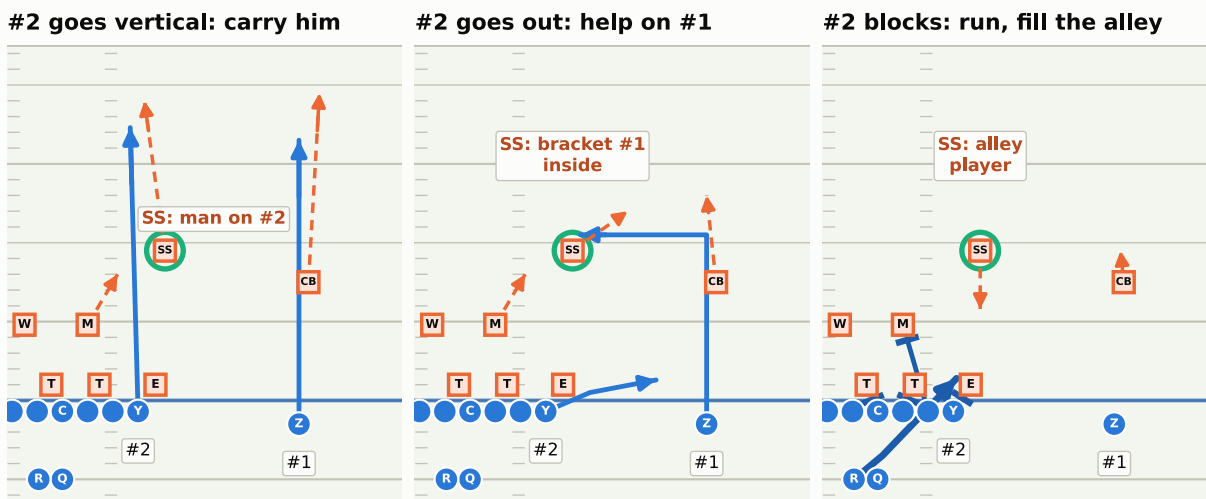


Figure 2: The strong safety's three answers to one key, the tight end Y (#2), on the offense's right. Left: Y releases straight up the seam, so the safety (ringed) turns and covers him like a man defender, while the corner goes deep with Z. Middle: Y releases to the flat, so the safety has no #2 to cover; he turns to the outside receiver (#1) and sits *inside* him, taking away Z's in-breaking route (here a dig) while the corner stays over the top: a bracket. The apex defender or a linebacker takes the flat. Right: Y blocks down on the end, a low, forward block that says run, so the safety comes downhill to fill the alley outside the tight end, and becomes the defense's extra run defender. Same alignment, three jobs; the receiver chose.

1. **#2 goes vertical: carry him.** If the inside receiver runs up the seam, the safety covers him, man-to-man, as deep as he goes. This is why quarters handles four verticals: each seam runner has a safety on him, and each outside runner has a corner.
2. **#2 goes short or out: help on #1.** If #2 runs to the flat or breaks off a short route, the safety has nobody to cover, so he turns to the outside receiver and sits *inside* him. Now #1 has the corner outside and over the top and the safety inside: a bracket, two defenders on one receiver. The dig and the post, the routes that hurt quarters corners most because they break away from the corner's outside position, run straight into the safety. (If #2 runs inside, across the field, many systems tell the safety to pass him to the linebackers and look for work: #1 breaking in, or a crossing route coming from the other side.)
3. **#2 blocks: it's a run, so fill.** If #2 is a tight end who blocks, or a slot receiver who steps up to block the apex defender, and the linemen in front of the safety fire out low, the safety reads run and comes downhill. In the language of Run Fits and Box Math, he becomes the alley player: he fills the lane between the edge and the box, inside-out, and he is the defense's plus-one.

Why does one receiver make such a good key? Because #2's release tells the safety, almost instantly, both whether the play is a run or a pass and where the danger is. A receiver who blocks is the strongest run signal there is. A receiver who releases vertical

is the danger. A receiver who runs to the flat isn't a deep threat, so the deep threat must be the outside man. Coaches love the economy of it: one key, read in the first step or two, answers the run-pass question and the coverage question at the same time.

That also explains where the safety stands. He has to be shallow enough to fill the alley before the running back gets through it, and deep enough to turn and run with a tight end up the seam without being beaten over the top. Nine or ten yards, a few yards inside #2, is the compromise. TCU's Gary Patterson, one of the coaches who made quarters famous in college football, taught his safeties not to backpedal at the snap at all but to shuffle flat-footed and read, because a safety rocking backward can't come forward in time.¹

🔥 Common misconception

"The safeties in quarters are deep defenders who sometimes help against the run." Turn it around. They are *readers* who become deep defenders only when #2 tells them to. On a run, the quarters safety is often the first or second defender to the ball; on a pass with #2 in the flat, he's breaking on the outside receiver's in-cut at 12 yards, not standing at 18. If you watch a quarters team on the All-22 film (the high, wide camera coaches use) and keep your eyes on one safety, you'll be surprised how rarely he ends the play deep.

Four verticals: the stress test quarters was built for

The best way to see why match rules matter is the play that broke spot-drop zones in the 1980s and 1990s: four verticals, four receivers running straight up the field. Against spot-drop Cover 3, four vertical routes meet three deep defenders, and one of them has to guard two receivers (Cover 3 shows the seam opening). Against quarters, the rules simply add up.

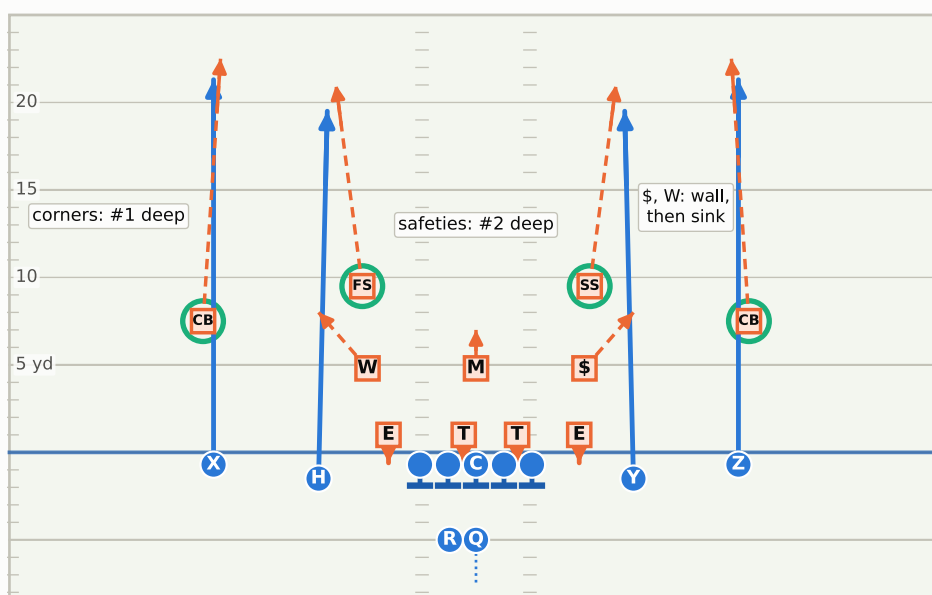


Figure 3: Four verticals against quarters from a spread 2x2 (the tight end flexed out as the right slot). Each corner (CB) takes #1 deep, man-to-man, because #1 went vertical; each safety (FS, SS) takes #2 deep, because #2 went vertical. The apex defenders (W on the left, \$ on the right) wall the slots for a step or two, then sink under the outside receivers. Four vertical routes, four deep defenders, each on top of a receiver: the play that strains Cover 3 hardest meets quarters' natural answer.

Notice what the defense didn't need: a decision. Nobody had to choose between two receivers; the rules assigned one defender to each. That's the deepest reason match coverage spread. Offenses had spent a generation designing routes that put two receivers in one zone defender's area, and match rules answered by making the zones follow the receivers. (Offenses answered back, of course: Dropback Concepts shows dagger and scissors, two concepts built to make a quarters safety's read work against him, and the weaknesses section below adds three more.)

¹Chris B. Brown, "Hard Knocks: Playing Defense With TCU's Gary Patterson," Grantland (Sept. 1, 2015): <https://grantland.com/features/hard-knocks-playing-defense-with-tcus-gary-patterson/> ("Other teams have their safeties backpedal, but we sit there and flat-foot shuffle," Patterson at a 2015 clinic).

The corner's rule: MOD and MEG

The safety's rule only works if the corner's rule fits with it. Quarters teams use two, and the names come from the playbook vocabulary that spread out of Nick Saban's defenses (more on that history below).

MOD, short for **man only deep**, is the standard quarters corner rule. The corner covers #1 man-to-man *if #1 runs a deep route*. If #1 breaks his route off short, about 5 yards or less (a hitch, a quick out, a slant, a shallow cross), the corner doesn't chase him. He passes him to the underneath defenders and drops into his deep quarter, looking for the next threat to come into it. In the version Cameron Soran decoded from Saban's playbooks, the rule reads, almost word for word: the corner is man-to-man on #1 except when #1 breaks at 5 yards or less; then he zones to the deep quarter. The safety's half of the same call: take all of #2 vertical; if #2 isn't vertical, bracket #1. And the apex defender's: take the first man to the flat, rerouting #2 first if he starts vertical.²

MEG, short for **man everywhere he goes**, is the other rule. The corner covers #1 on every route, short or deep, no exceptions. You met MEG in Cover 3 as the backside corner's rule in a trips check; it shows up all over match coverage, wherever a defense needs one corner to take care of his man alone so that the defenders around him can do something else.

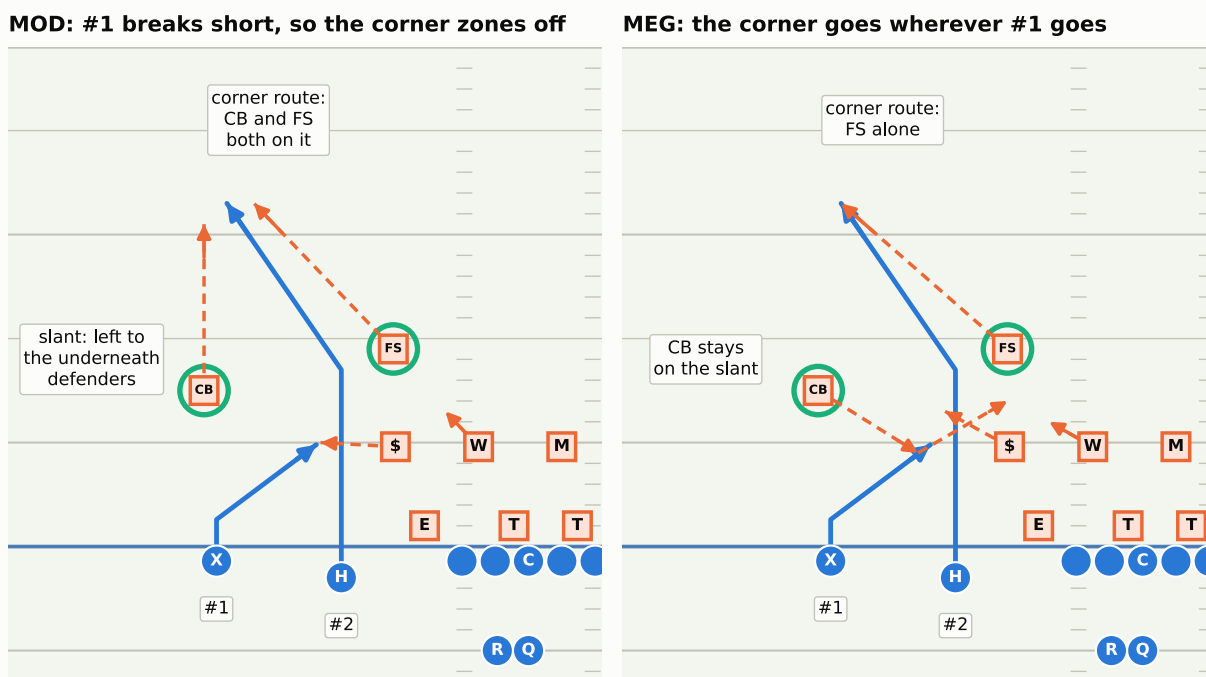


Figure 4: MOD and MEG against the same two routes, offense's left side: X (#1) runs a quick slant, H (#2) a corner route toward the sideline. Left, MOD: X broke inside at 2 yards, so the corner (CB, ringed) lets him go to the underneath defenders (the nickel, \$, drives on the slant) and drops into his deep quarter, right where H's corner route is heading. The free safety (FS, ringed) carries H because H went vertical. Result: two defenders on the corner route, the slant left to the defenders in front of it. Right, MEG: the corner goes with X on the slant, so the corner route is the free safety's alone, and it breaks away from him toward the sideline.

The trade is clear in the two panels.

- **MOD keeps the corner deep and gives the defense extra help on the dangerous routes.** Short routes by #1 are left to the defenders who are already in front of them (the apex defender, the linebackers), who can rally and tackle for a short gain. The corner, freed from the short route, becomes a second defender on whatever goes deep on his side, often #2 breaking outside, as here. The cost: the short throw to #1 is there if the underneath defenders are slow to it, and a receiver who fakes short and goes deep (a stop-and-go, a slant-and-go) can catch a MOD corner who passed him off too early.
- **MEG locks the corner on his man and frees everyone else.** The safety no longer has to worry about #1, so he can play #2 alone, or leave his side entirely to help elsewhere (that is how the trips checks of Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage

²Cameron Soran, "The Complete Guide to Nick Saban Coverages at Alabama," Throw Deep Publishing (Feb. 24, 2021): <https://throwdeeppublishing.com/blogs/news/nick-saban-s-alabama-pass-coverages>. MOD: "The corner will be man-to-man on all #1 except when #1 breaks at 5 yards or less (e.g., shallow cross, 5 yard hitch). If #1 breaks at 5 yards or less, zone to deep quarter." Safety: "Take all of #2 vertical. If #2 is not vertical, then bracket #1." Apex: "Take the first man to the flat... If #2 begins to go vertical, always reroute #2." MEG: "Man Everywhere he Goes... the corner will man up on #1 for everything (no exceptions)." In Saban's version the MOD corner begins in press; most quarters teams play it from off alignments.

find a spare defender). The cost: the corner is on an island with no inside help, and every route that breaks away from him, especially a slant or a dig against an off corner, is his problem alone. MEG needs a corner the defense trusts.

A defense picks between them by situation and by personnel. A team with one great corner might play him MEG on the opponent's best receiver and MOD on the other side. Against a lone receiver in a trips formation, MEG on the backside corner is the standard way to free the backside safety. And in the red zone, where there is little deep field left to protect, MEG becomes more common because "deep" barely exists.

i Go deeper: rules that agree with each other

The magic of a match coverage isn't any one rule; it's that the rules fit together like a contract. MOD says "I'll let #1 go if he's short." The apex rule says "I'll take the first man to the flat," and the hook defender says "I'll take what comes inside." Between them, every short route by #1 has an owner. The safety's rule says "if #2 isn't vertical, bracket #1," which covers the one thing MOD gives up deep. Change one clause, from MOD to MEG for example, and every other player's clause shifts with it. That is why match defenses talk so much before the snap, and why offenses use motion and route combinations designed to land exactly on the seam between two players' rules.

Quarters against the run: the safeties fit from depth

Now the part of quarters that made it a run defense. Look back at the alignment: four defensive linemen and two linebackers in the box, six defenders, against five offensive linemen and a tight end, six blockers. By the box count of A First Look at Defense that is a light box: every run defender can be blocked and nobody is left over. A defense playing one-high would usually have walked its strong safety down to make it seven against six.

Quarters gets its seventh (and sometimes eighth) run defender from 9 or 10 yards away. The safety reads #2; when #2 blocks and the linemen fire out low, he comes downhill into the alley. College coaches with a 4-3 front (four linemen, three linebackers) like to describe 4-3 quarters as a "nine-man front": seven defenders near the line and two safeties who arrive as run defenders when the play is a run. In the NFL's nickel defense the count is lower, but the idea is the same.

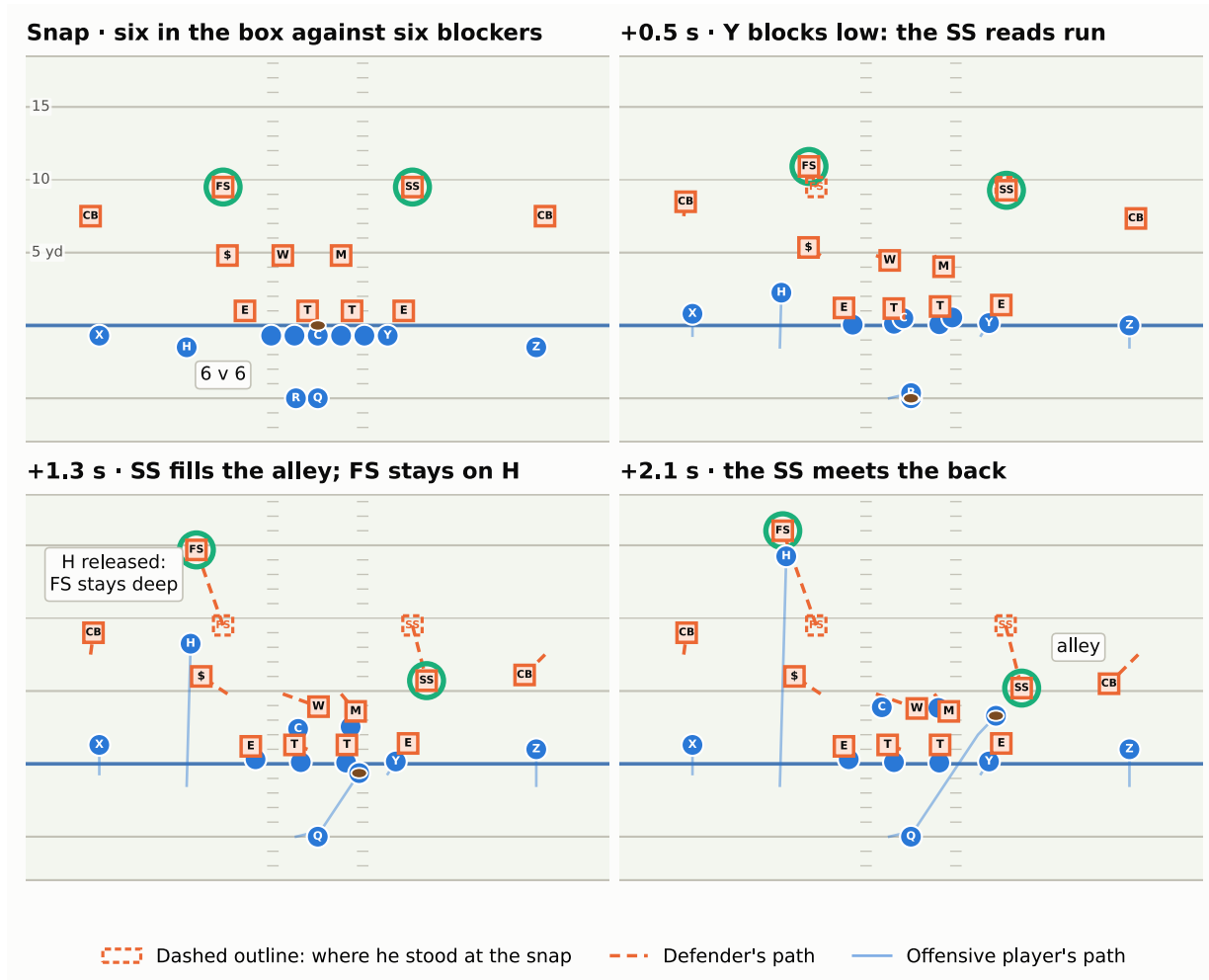


Figure 5: Quarters against inside zone, frame by frame (simulated). Snap: six defenders in the box against six blockers, with both safeties (ringed) 9 to 10 yards deep. +0.5 s: the tight end Y (the strong safety's #2) fires out low to block the end, and the line steps right: run. +1.3 s: the strong safety (SS) is already coming downhill into the alley outside the tight end, while the free safety (FS), whose #2 (H) released up the field, stays with him: H took the FS out of the run fit. +2.1 s: the ball carrier (the brown ball) bends the run outside and the SS meets him three or four yards downfield. The dashed outlines show where the safeties stood at the snap.

Three things in that play are worth slowing down for.

The trigger is a read, not a call. The strong safety didn't know before the snap that this would be a run. He found out from Y's block in the first half-second, and he went. That is the difference between quarters and the rotation of Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage, where a safety is *told* before the snap to come down at the snap, read or no read. The called rotation arrives sooner; the read arrives later but is never fooled into abandoning the deep field on a pass. Quarters chooses the read.

He meets the back past the line of scrimmage. Even from 9 or 10 yards, the safety is a beat late compared with a linebacker standing at 4 or 5. He typically makes the play three to five yards downfield, which is roughly the bargain Run Fits and Box Math describes for the two-high light box: give up a four-yard run, never a forty-yard pass.

The other safety went with his receiver. The free safety's #2, H, released up the field, which is a pass read, so the free safety stayed with him and was out of the run fit. That is the offense's main weapon against quarters' run defense, and it costs the offense nothing: a receiver who runs a route on a running play removes a safety from the fit. Offenses with a good slot receiver run the ball *away* from the tight end for exactly this reason, and RPOs take it one step further by letting the quarterback read that safety and throw to the receiver if the safety comes down anyway.

The edge on the tight end's side belongs to the end lined up outside him (the contain player), and the corner comes up outside-in once his receiver, Z, blocks him. On the slot side, the nickel at the apex is both the force player and the first man to the flat, the overhang defender job. Names and exact assignments vary by staff; the geometry, an outside defender who forces and a safety who fills inside him, doesn't.

! Why it exists: run support from the secondary

What it solves. Most of the time a defense that wants an extra run defender has to *show* him: a safety walked down to 7 or 8 yards before the snap, which tells the offense to throw. Quarters hides the extra defender inside a two-high picture and lets the offense's own blocking call him into the fit. Every running play is met by six defenders in the box plus one or two who arrive late from depth, and every pass is met by two safeties who never left.

What it gives up. Time and certainty. The safety arrives after the back has crossed the line, so quarters gives up more yards per run than an eight-man box, and the safety must tackle in space, at full speed, with nobody behind him. And because the trigger is a read, anything that disguises the read, a play-action fake, a receiver who blocks and then releases, a running back running at the safety's alley before the quarterback throws over it, attacks the coverage at its heart.

Cover 6: quarters on one side, Cover 2 on the other

Quarters works beautifully when each side of the formation has two receivers. Formations don't always cooperate, and the most common alternative is to split the field. **Cover 6** plays quarters on one half of the field and Cover 2 on the other, which is why coaches also call it *quarter-quarter-half* (the corner and safety each take a quarter on one side; one safety takes the whole half on the other). The number is dialect, not law: in Vic Fangio's vocabulary the same idea is called Cover 8 (Coverage Fundamentals has the dialect notes).

Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage shows Cover 6 against a 2x2 set split by field position (quarters to the wide side, Cover 2 to the short side). Here it is against the formation that most often calls for it, a 3x1 trips set, with the split made by formation: quarters to the three receivers, Cover 2 to the single receiver.

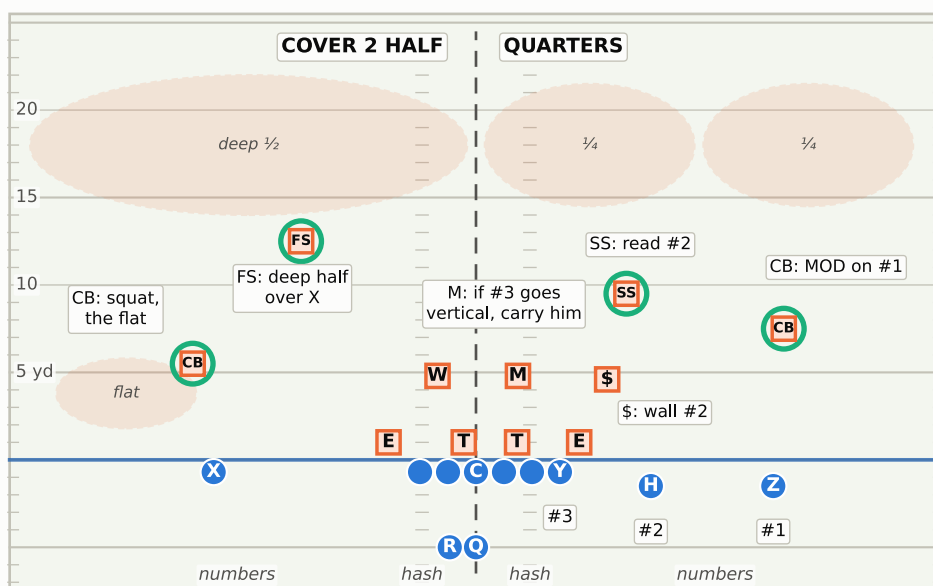


Figure 6: Cover 6 against 3x1 (trips right, the tight end Y attached as #3). The dashed line splits the two halves. Right, toward the three receivers, quarters: the corner plays MOD on #1 (Z), the strong safety reads #2 (H), the nickel (\$) walls #2 from the apex, and the Mike carries #3 (Y) if he runs up the middle. Left, toward the lone receiver X, Cover 2: the corner squats 5 yards off with outside leverage to take the flat and short outside throws, and the free safety (FS) stands deeper and wider, about 12 to 13 yards deep between the hash and the numbers, to take the whole deep half over X. Before the snap the halves already disagree: one shallow corner and one deep, one deep wide safety and one shallow inside one. That asymmetry is the Cover 6 tell.

Why put Cover 2 on the lone receiver? Look at what the two defenders on that side are doing to X. The squat corner sits in front of him, taking away the quick out, the hitch and the flat; the half-field safety sits over the top of him, taking away the go route. X is bracketed under and over by two defenders, which is more help than most single receivers ever see. That matters because offenses put their best receiver alone on the backside of trips precisely to get him a one-on-one matchup. Cover 6 says no.

The cost is on the trips side, where four defenders (corner, safety, nickel and Mike) have to handle three receivers who can all run deep. The quarters rules cover #1 and #2. The problem is #3, the tight end, if he runs straight up the middle: the Mike has to carry

him, a linebacker running with a tight end down the seam, and if #2 and #3 both run vertical the strong safety can take only one of them. That is the trips problem in its purest form, and every two-high defense carries a set of answers to it (poach, solo, stubbie), which Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage covers in detail. Cover 6 is the simplest answer: give the lone receiver to two defenders, and trust four on three.

Cover 6 is also how Cover 2 survived. Cover 2 and Tampa 2 showed why a whole defense of squat corners and half-field safeties became too easy to attack; as *half* of a coverage, aimed at the side of the field where it's strongest (the short side, or a lone receiver), Cover 2 still earns its keep. By NFL Next Gen Stats' count, Cover 6 was 9.2% of coverages in 2025.³

How do you see it after the snap? Count the deep safeties (two: the middle of the field is open), then watch the corners. If both bail to deep quarters with their eyes on the quarterback, it's quarters. If both squat in the flats, Cover 2. One squatting and one bailing: Cover 6, and the squatting corner shows you the Cover 2 half.

Palms: the corner who traps the out

Quarters has one obvious soft spot, and you can find it in the first figure: the flat. With the corner 8 yards deep and playing #1, the safety reading #2 from 9 yards and the apex defender walling #2, a quick throw to #2 breaking toward the sideline lands in front of everyone. Offenses learned to throw it all day: the slot receiver's quick out, the "now" throw to the flat, the out route by the slot in a smash-type concept.

Palms is the answer. The same coverage goes by **2-read** and, because of what the corner does, **trap coverage**. Different staffs use different names for it and slightly different rules, but the core is one adjustment on one side of the field: **the corner reads #2 instead of #1**.

- If #2 breaks *out* quickly (inside the first 5 yards or so), the corner leaves #1 and jumps #2's out or flat route. He was 6 or 7 yards deep with his eyes inside, so he's coming forward into the throw, not chasing it. That is the trap.
- The safety, seeing #2 go out, takes #1 deep: he's now the deep defender over the outside receiver whom the corner just left. In Saban's version the safety's rule reads: take #1 vertical if #2 is out in the first 5 yards; otherwise, take all of #2 vertical, and if #2 isn't vertical, bracket #1.⁴
- If #2 goes vertical, nothing special happens: the safety carries #2, the corner stays on #1, and it plays like quarters.

³James Reber, NFL Next Gen Stats, "The coverage that turned the Seahawks into Super Bowl winners and is taking the NFL by storm," NFL.com (2026): <https://www.nfl.com/news/the-coverage-that-turned-the-seahawks-into-super-bowl-winners-and-is-taking-the-nfl-by-storm> (2025 coverage rates: Cover 4 17.2%, Cover 2 13.9%, Cover 6 9.2%).

⁴Soran's guide, cited in full in the note on MOD and MEG: Palms, strong safety: "Take #1 vertical if #2 is out in first 5 yards. Otherwise, take all of #2 vertical. If #2 is not vertical, then bracket #1." The names vary by staff: "Palms," "2-read," "Cobra" and "trap" are all used for corner-reads-#2 coverages, and some playbooks use "Palms" for a broader family.

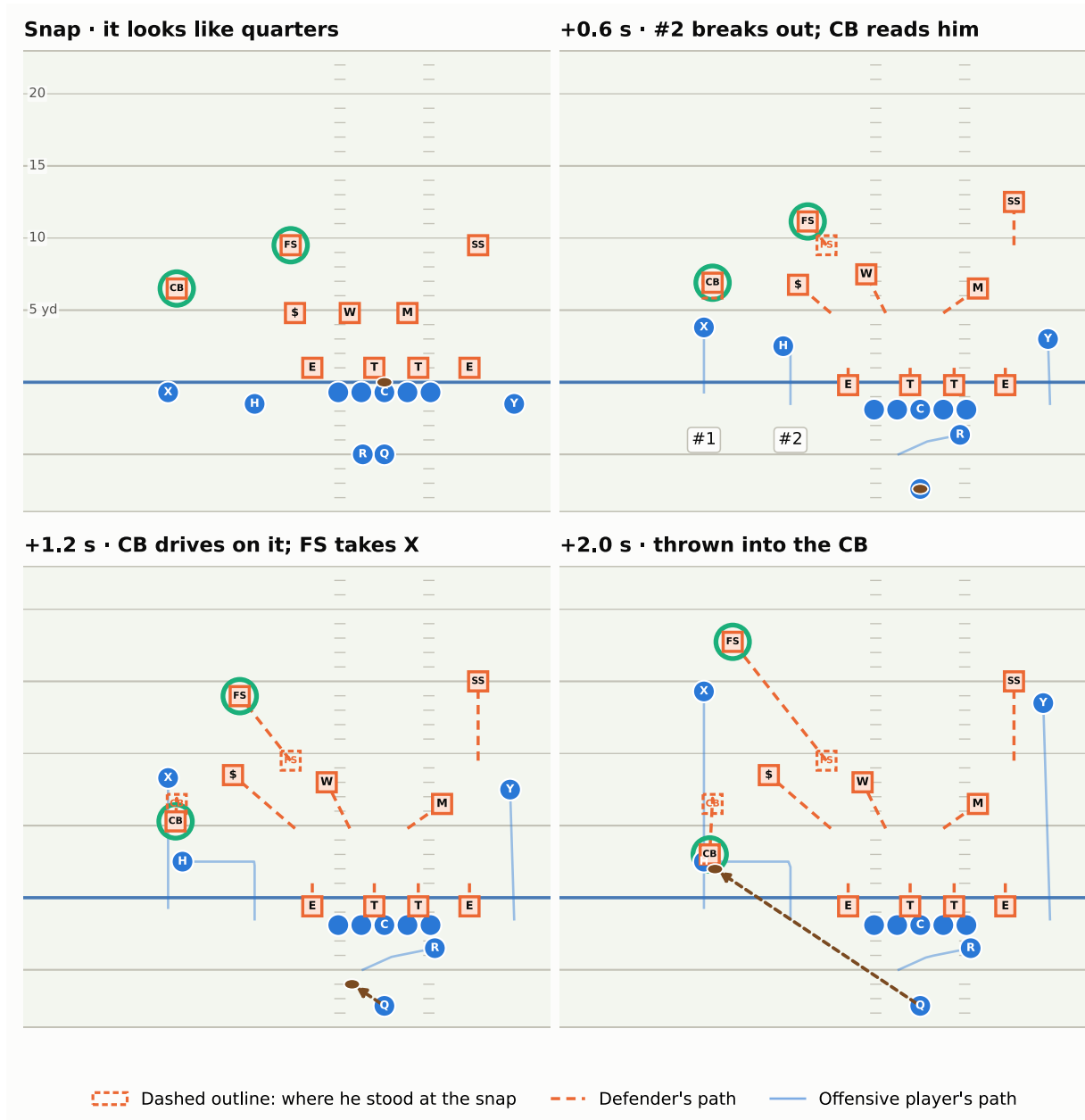


Figure 7: Palms on the offense's left, frame by frame (simulated). Snap: the picture is quarters, except that the corner (CB, ringed) is a little shallower and inside X, with his eyes inside on H, the #2 receiver. +0.6 s: H breaks to the sideline on a quick out at 4 yards; the corner's eyes are on him, and the free safety (FS, ringed) sees it too. +1.2 s: the corner has left X and is driving forward on the out; the free safety has turned and is taking X deep. +2.0 s: the quarterback, who saw an off corner before the snap and thought the out would be open, throws it, and the ball arrives with the corner already in the throwing lane. The dashed outlines show where the corner and safety stood at the snap.

Watch the timing. The out route is a rhythm throw: the quarterback decides before the snap, takes his drop and lets it go as #2 breaks, about a second after the snap. He threw it because the corner looked like a quarters corner, 7 yards off and playing the outside receiver. But a Palms corner's eyes were on #2 from the start, and he started forward the moment #2 broke. Against a throw that travels 15 or more yards across the field, a defender coming *downhill* toward the sideline gets to the catch point first. That's how quick outs become interceptions returned the other way.

Palms also cleans up two of the routes Cover 2 and Tampa 2 found hardest. Against smash (a hitch by #1, a corner route by #2), #2's corner route starts vertical, so the safety carries it, and the hitch runs into the corner sitting in front of #1. Against a slot's flat route paired with a curl by #1, the corner jumps the flat and the safety, who no longer has a vertical #2, drives on the curl from inside.

! Why it exists: taking away the throw quarters gives up

What it solves. Quarters concedes quick outside throws to #2. Palms puts a defender on them without adding one: the corner, who in plain quarters would have been 8 yards deep over a #1 who isn't going deep, trades jobs with the safety, who in plain quarters would have had nothing to do once #2 went to the flat. Nobody new comes onto the field; two players swap rules.

What it gives up. The trap is a guess about the route, and good offenses bait it. A #2 who breaks out and then turns up the sideline (an out-and-up, or a wheel) runs right past the jumping corner, and the safety is busy with #1. A #1 who runs a double move against a safety coming from inside can win too. And the corner who reads #2 is, for a moment, not watching #1 at all, so a fast #1 on a quick slant inside him can be open in the first second. Defenses mix Palms with plain quarters for exactly this reason: a corner who always traps gets beaten by the play designed for him.

How do you spot it? Before the snap, the corner on the Palms side tends to be a yard or two shallower than a quarters corner, often lined up a little inside #1, with his eyes turned to the slot. After the snap the tell is unmistakable: the corner comes *forward* toward the line, toward #2, while the safety on that side runs *outward and deep* over #1. The two cross like a pair of scissors. Palms is usually played to one side, often toward the short side of the field or against a 2x2 side, while the other half plays its own call, which makes it another piece of the split-field toolbox.

Why two-high match took over the NFL, 2018 to 2025

None of this was new in 2018. What changed is how much NFL defenses used it. NFL Next Gen Stats (the league's tracking-data arm) measures how often defenses play a split-safety (two-high) coverage after the snap: 32.9% of dropbacks in 2018, 37.8% in 2021, 40.4% in 2024 and 42.0% in 2025, the highest since its tracking began. Quarters was the biggest single piece: Cover 4 alone was 17.2% of 2025 coverages by Next Gen Stats' count, against a 2018–2024 average of 13.9%, with Cover 2 at 13.9% and Cover 6 at 9.2%.⁵ You can rebuild the trend yourself from the free nflverse data, with one big caveat.

⁵Same NFL.com Next Gen Stats article as the note on Cover 6 (split-safety rate 32.9% in 2018, 37.8% in 2021, 40.4% in 2024, 42.0% in 2025; every defense above 30% in 2025). The 2018–2024 Cover 4 average of 13.9% comes from the same Next Gen Stats analysis. A different series from TruMedia/538, measured on early downs only (26.8% in 2019 to 34.6% in 2024), circulates widely and should not be mixed with this one.

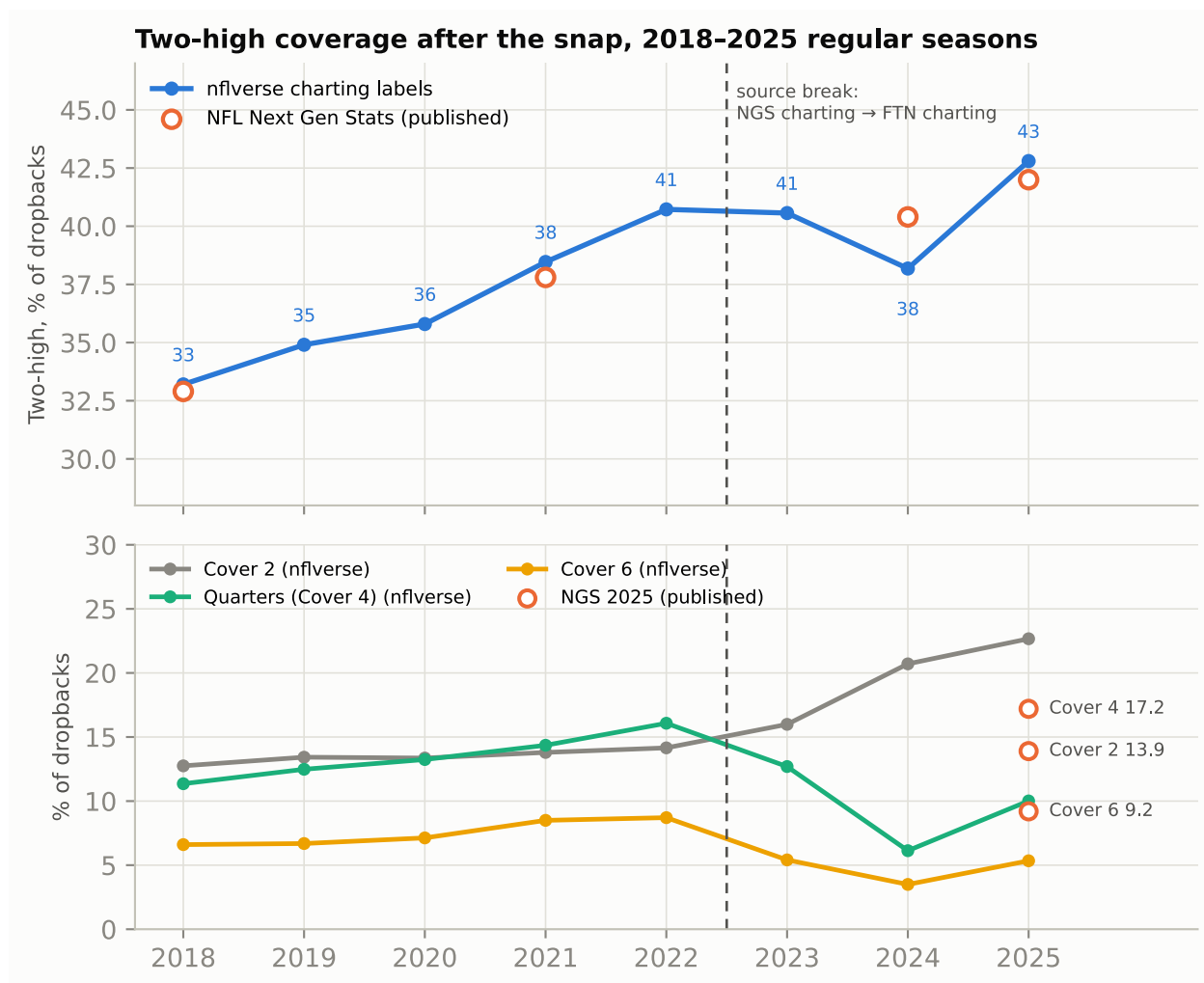


Figure 8: Top: share of charted regular-season dropbacks played as a two-high coverage after the snap (Cover 2, 2-Man, quarters or Cover 6), 2018–2025. Blue: the nflverse charting labels; orange rings: the figures NFL Next Gen Stats published. Both rise from about a third of dropbacks to over 40%. Bottom: the components, from the same labels. Here the source break matters: the coverage labels come from NGS charting through 2022 and from FTN Data charting from 2023 (dashed line), and the two charters sort two-high snaps differently. FTN calls far more of them Cover 2 and far fewer quarters than NGS did, and Next Gen Stats’ own counts for 2025 (orange rings at right) put quarters at 17.2%, against 10.0% in the FTN labels. Read each side of the line on its own: before it, quarters and Cover 6 climb steadily; after it, the total is consistent but the split between Cover 2 and quarters is a charting choice, not a trend.

The top panel is the trend, and the two sources agree on it: about a third of dropbacks in 2018, over 40% by 2022 and again in 2025, with a dip in 2024 that only the nflverse labels show.⁶ The bottom panel is a lesson in reading charting data. Through 2022 the components climb together; after the switch from NGS to FTN charting, quarters appears to collapse while Cover 2 soars. Nothing like that happened on the field. Two different groups of people watching film drew the line between “two safeties guarding halves” and “two safeties reading #2” in different places, and NGS’s own 2025 counts, shown as rings, disagree with the FTN labels by close to a factor of two in both directions (more quarters, less Cover 2). Both are honest; quarters and Cover 2 look alike before the snap and for a beat after it, and the difference is in rules a charter has to infer. Use the total, which is robust, and be careful with the split. (The nflverse data has the same kind of break in its man/zone labels, which is why Man Coverage doesn’t chart a man-coverage trend across 2022–2025.)

Why the rise? No single cause, but five reasons show up again and again in coaches’ and analysts’ explanations, and they reinforce each other.

⁶Course calculation from nflverse `load_participation()`, 2018–2025 regular seasons (Weeks 1–17 through 2020, 1–18 from 2021), rows with a charted `defense_coverage_type`, excluding BLOWN, COMBO and PREVENT; two-high = COVER_2 + 2_MAN + COVER_4 + COVER_6 (COVER_9, which appears only from 2023, is counted as neither). Labels come from NGS for 2016–2022 and from FTN for 2023–2025, with different label sets, and none exist for 2016–2017. Small differences from other published nflverse calculations come from the filters.

1. **Explosive passes became the thing to stop.** By the late 2010s the passing game was more efficient than it had ever been, and the plays that decide games are the long completions (Expected Points and Success Rate shows why a 40-yard pass is worth so much more than a 4-yard run). The 2018 season was the loudest version: Patrick Mahomes threw 50 touchdown passes in his first year as a starter, and the Rams beat his Chiefs 54–51 on a Monday night in November.⁷ Two deep safeties are the most direct protection against the explosive pass, and quarters keeps two deep without giving up the run.
2. **Match rules answered the spread passing game.** Offenses built on four verticals, mesh and flood concepts, and on putting two receivers in one zone defender's area, ran into zones that followed the receivers. Quarters gives four deep matchers against four vertical threats.
3. **The extra run defender could come from depth.** A defense that played one-high with an eighth man in the box was guessing run every snap, and run-pass options punished that guess (RPOs). Quarters' read safeties are harder to put in conflict before the snap, because their run job is decided by the play itself.
4. **Two-high pictures disguise everything.** From a two-high shell a defense can play quarters, Cover 6, Palms, Cover 2 or 2-Man, or rotate into a one-high coverage at the snap. The more of those it plays, the less the quarterback learns before the snap (Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage).
5. **Coaching trees and a college pipeline.** Coaches who learned split-field quarters in college (more below) reached NFL staffs, and one NFL tree in particular, that of Vic Fangio, the long-time defensive coordinator whose two-high defenses in Chicago and Denver became the model, spread the approach through the league. Fangio's own story, and the counterpunch that followed, is a case study: Fangio's Two-High Revolution and Macdonald's Answer.

There is a sixth condition that isn't a cause so much as a price of admission: **a four-man rush that can win.** A light box and two deep safeties work only if four rushers can pressure the quarterback without help, because nobody else is coming. The defenses that lived in two-high were also the ones with dominant interior rushers, a pattern you'll see in the film room.

And offenses answered. If quarters invites the run against a light box, run it; if it reads #2, make #2 a blocker. The 2024 and 2025 seasons brought more two- and three-tight-end personnel and more snaps under center, the subject of The Modern Era.

A short history: from Cleveland to East Lansing and Iowa City

Four defenders deep is an old idea; prevent defenses have used it for decades. The modern version, quarters as a read coverage whose safeties fit the run, is mostly a product of college football in the 1990s and 2000s, with one important root in the NFL.

That root is Cleveland. Nick Saban was Bill Belichick's defensive coordinator with the Browns from 1991 to 1994, and the pattern-matching rules the two developed there, first for Cover 3 and then for the quarters family, went with Saban to Michigan State as head coach in 1995 and later to LSU and Alabama.⁸ Saban's vocabulary is the one this chapter has been using: MOD and MEG for the corners, Palms, Stubbie and other per-side calls, "Cover 7" for his quarters-based family of split-field calls (Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage covers Cover 7), and "Rip" and "Liz," the strong safety's declaration of which side he is rotating to, in his match Cover 3 (Cover 3). One set of match rules, several coverages: that's the Saban-Belichick inheritance, and it's why the "match" in this chapter's title covers Cover 3 match as much as quarters. Like most who-invented-it stories, this one has rivals; other staffs were building match rules at the same time, and the coverage numbers themselves meant different things in different buildings.

Michigan State kept the quarters thread alive after Saban left. Under head coach Mark Dantonio, who had coached Saban's secondary in East Lansing, and defensive coordinator Pat Narduzzi (2007–2014), the Spartans' 4-3 quarters became one of the most studied defenses in the country; Narduzzi gave long clinic talks on it. His own conversion is a good story. In 2002, as a Northern Illinois assistant, he watched Miami (Ohio) quarterback Ben Roethlisberger complete 41 of 61 passes for 525 yards against his defense's two-deep look. When he became Miami's defensive coordinator the next year, he went to Cover 4, which, as a FootballScoop account of his 2014 clinic talk put it, "turned Big Ben into Moderately Sized Ben."⁹ By 2013 Narduzzi's defense led

⁷"2018 Kansas City Chiefs season," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2018_Kansas_City_Chiefs_season (Mahomes's 50 touchdown passes and MVP award; the 54–51 loss to the Rams on Monday Night Football, Nov. 19, 2018, at the Los Angeles Memorial Coliseum). Pro Football Reference blocks automated checks; spot-check there before print.

⁸Saban's pattern-matching Cover 3 "prior to his association with Belichick with the Browns in the early 1990s simply did not exist," in Cameron Soran's guide (cited in the note on MOD and MEG), which also treats Cover 7 as "a form of quarters coverage" and explains Rip/Liz as "the safety's declaration... of which side he is coming down." Dates: Kyle Jones, "Film Study: Nick Saban's Influence on Mark Dantonio and Ohio State's 2002 National Title Run Is Undeniable," *Eleven Warriors* (Mar. 23, 2020): <https://elevenwarriors.com/ohio-state-football/film-study/2020/03/112969/film-study-nick-sabans-influence-on-mark-dantonio-and-ohio-states-2002-national-title-run-is-undeniable> (Saban was Cleveland's defensive coordinator from 1991 to 1994, left for Michigan State in 1995 and hired Dantonio to coach the secondary).

⁹Zach Barnett, "How Ben Roethlisberger and Urban Meyer shaped Pat Narduzzi's defensive philosophy," *FootballScoop* (June 25, 2014): <https://footballscoop.com/news/how-ben-roethlisberger-and-urban-meyer-shaped-pat-narduzzi-s-defensive-philosophy> (Narduzzi was coaching linebackers at Northern Illinois in 2002; Roethlisberger went "41-of-61 passes for 525 yards with four touchdowns against three interceptions" in Northern Illinois's 48–41 win on Oct. 12, 2002; Narduzzi's 80-minute Cover 4 talk at the Angelo Football Clinic).

the nation in total defense through the regular season, allowing 248.2 yards a game, and he won the Broyles Award as the country's top assistant coach.¹⁰

Iowa is the other long-running reference point. Norm Parker installed his 4-3 defense when Kirk Ferentz took over the program at the end of the 1990s, and Phil Parker (no relation), the defensive coordinator since 2012, kept it: a front that holds up against the run while the safeties play split-field quarters behind it, year after year.¹¹ TCU's Gary Patterson built a 4-2-5 around the same idea. When NFL defenses went looking for a two-high answer to the spread offenses of the late 2010s, this is where the coaching knowledge was.

Where quarters breaks

Every coverage has holes, and the holes of quarters follow directly from its rules. The curriculum of any offensive coordinator facing a quarters team starts with three of them.

Light-box runs

You've already seen the first. Quarters plays six defenders in the box against six blockers and counts on the safeties to arrive late. That works only if the safeties are *free* to arrive. Offenses take them away in three ways:

- **Release #2.** A slot receiver or tight end who runs a route on a running play turns his safety into a pass defender, as H did to the free safety in the run-fit figure. Now the box is six against six with one late helper, not two.
- **Add a blocker.** Two-tight-end and fullback sets make #2 a blocker who blocks *the safety*, or add a seventh blocker so that the light box is outnumbered. The rise of heavier personnel in 2024 and 2025 was partly this.
- **Read him.** An RPO hands the ball off if the safety stays deep and throws behind him if he comes down, so the read that makes quarters work becomes the read that beats it.

The defense's counters are a front that can hold its gaps without help (which is why two-high defenses prize big interior linemen), safeties who tackle in space, and a willingness to give up four-yard runs. Run Fits and Box Math has the data on what runs against light boxes actually gain.

The bootleg flood

Play-action attacks any coverage whose defenders read the run. Quarters is special because its *deep* defenders read the run.

¹⁰Associated Press, "Michigan State's Narduzzi wins Broyles Award," *Arkansas Democrat-Gazette* (Dec. 10, 2013): <https://www.arkansasonline.com/news/2013/dec/10/michigan-states-narduzzi-wins-broyles-award/> ("Michigan State leads the nation this season in total defense and third the nation in scoring defense, holding opponents to 248.2 yards and 11.3 points per game"; Narduzzi had been MSU's defensive coordinator since 2007). Final 2013 national rankings after the bowl games may differ slightly. Narduzzi left to become Pittsburgh's head coach in December 2014: Michigan State Athletics, "Pat Narduzzi Named Head Football Coach at Pittsburgh" (Dec. 26, 2014): https://msuspartans.com/news/2014/12/26/Pat_Narduzzi_Named_Head_Football_Coach_at_Pittsburgh.

¹¹Phil Parker was named Iowa's defensive coordinator in February 2012, succeeding Norm Parker, who had run the defense since Kirk Ferentz's arrival: BTN.com staff, "Ferentz names Phil Parker DC, rearranges staff" (Feb. 7, 2012): <https://btn.com/2012/02/07/ferentz-names-phil-parker-dc-rearranges-staff>. On the scheme: Cody Alexander, "Fitting The Run With The Iowa Hawkeyes," *MatchQuarters* (June 13, 2024): <https://www.matchquarters.com/p/fitting-the-run-iowa-hawkeyes-phil-parker-4-3> ("Phil Parker & Co. have taken the air out of their opponents' run games utilizing their Under 4-3 Quarters defense").

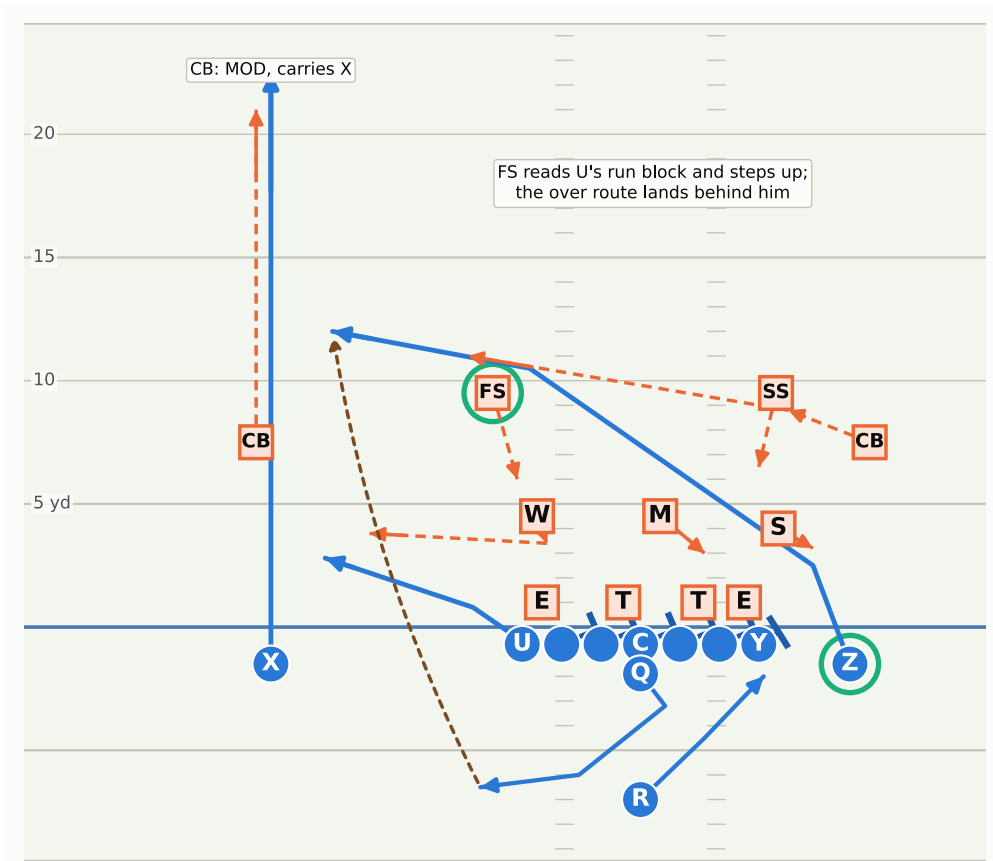


Figure 9: A bootleg flood against quarters (12 personnel: two tight ends, U on the left and Y on the right; Z in a tight split). The offense fakes an outside zone run to the right and the quarterback rolls left. Left side, three receivers at three depths: X runs deep and the corner (MOD) carries him; U fakes a block, then releases to the flat; Z runs a deep over route from the far side. The free safety (ringed) reads U, his #2, and U's fake block says run, so he steps up. The over route lands at about 12 yards, behind him and in front of the corner, with the trailing corner from the other side chasing. The strong safety, keyed on Y's block, stepped up too.

Walk through it from the defense's side, and every defender did his job. The free safety read #2, saw a run block, and came forward: correct by his rule. The corner saw #1 go deep and went with him: correct, MOD. The linebacker on that side saw a run fake, stepped up, then chased the tight end to the flat: correct. And the over route, coming from the other side of the field, entered the space between the corner (deep with X) and the safety (up for the run) where *nobody's rule* put a defender. That is a flood: three receivers at three depths on one side, against defenders whose first read sent them the wrong way.

It isn't that play-action is magic against quarters in particular. In the nflverse charting for 2023–2025, play-action raised the average result of a dropback against quarters by about as much as it did against Cover 3 or Cover 1.¹² The point is *which* play-action. A run fake that pulls the safeties forward, paired with a deep crosser from the far side, attacks the exact gap between quarters' corner rule and its safety rule. The defense's counter is discipline in the read (safeties taught to key through the blocker to the guards and the quarterback, not just #2's first step) and calls that tell the safety on the bootleg side to stay deep no matter what, at the cost of the run fit.

The running back's wheel

The third weakness hides in the rule for the apex defender: *take the first man to the flat*.

¹²Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play (regular-season dropbacks with EPA), joined to `load_participation()` coverage labels and FTN charting's `is_play_action`, 2023–2025: average EPA per dropback without and with play-action was 0.02 and 0.13 against COVER_4 (n = 4,835 and 888), 0.02 and 0.16 against COVER_3, and 0.01 and 0.13 against COVER_1. Play-action helps the offense against nearly every coverage by a similar margin.

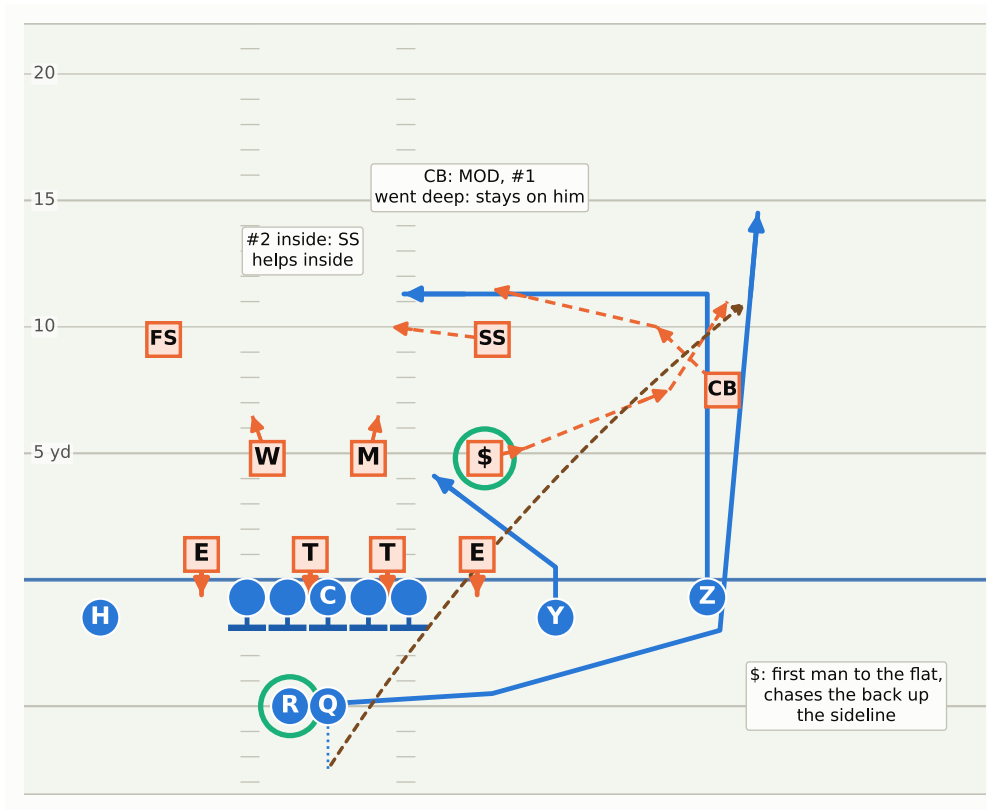


Figure 10: The running back's wheel against quarters, offense's right side. Z (#1) runs a dig, past 5 yards, so the corner (MOD) stays on him and follows him inside. Y (#2) runs a quick slant inside, so the strong safety, with no vertical #2, works inside to help. The running back releases to the flat, the nickel (\$, ringed) takes him as the first man to the flat, and then the back turns up the sideline. The nickel has to run with a running back down the field with no help: the corner and the safety have both gone inside with the routes in front of them. The deep outside quarter is empty.

Each rule is reasonable on its own. Together, the routes in front of the corner and the safety pulled both of them inside, and the back's route started as a flat route (the apex defender's) and became a deep route down the sideline (nobody's). The defender left with him is a nickel back or a linebacker, chasing a running back from behind, with an empty deep quarter in front of them. The wheel is the classic match-coverage beater because it *changes category* in the middle of the play: short when the rules assign it, deep when it's caught.

Defenses answer by teaching the apex player to "carry" a flat route that turns up and by telling the corner, when #1 goes inside, to look for something coming outside behind him. Both answers cost something somewhere else, which is the theme of the whole chapter. The offense's side of all this, the full menu of concepts aimed at quarters' rules, is the job of Concepts Versus Coverages.

¹³Course calculation from nflverse `load_participation()` (NGS charting), 2020 regular season, dropbacks with a charted coverage (BLOWN and PREVENT excluded): Rams 20.6% COVER_4 and 15.5% COVER_6 (n = 548); 49ers 40.1% and Bears 37.3% quarters-plus-Cover 6; league 20.4%.

¹⁴Kaelen Jones, "The Rams Defense Has L.A. on the Cusp of Another Deep Playoff Run," The Ringer (Jan. 13, 2021): <https://theringer.com/2021/01/13/nfl/rams-defense-los-angeles-brandon-staley-aaron-donald-jalen-ramsey> (Staley's years on Fangio's staffs in Chicago and Denver; Ramsey used outside and as the nickel or "star"; "much lighter boxes").

Film room

i Film room: Rams 2020 — quarters and Cover 6 as a base

Brandon Staley's one season as the Rams' defensive coordinator is usually told as a story about disguise (Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage tells it that way). Underneath the disguise was a lot of plain quarters. In the nflverse charting for the 2020 regular season, the Rams played quarters or Cover 6 on 36.1% of charted dropbacks, third-most in the league behind San Francisco and Chicago, against a league rate of 20.4%.¹³ Staley had come from Fangio's staffs in Chicago and Denver, and the Rams had the two players a quarters defense most wants: Aaron Donald, an interior pass rusher who could win with four, and Jalen Ramsey, a cornerback who could play outside or in the slot.¹⁴

What to notice: on a Rams early down from 2020, check the safeties' depth before the snap. They are often at 10 yards or less, over the slot or the tight end, not at 13 on the hashes. Then watch the first step of the safety on the tight end's side. On runs he comes downhill into the alley; on passes with the tight end releasing, he turns and runs with him. Against trips, watch for the squat corner and deep safety over the lone receiver: Cover 6.

i Film room: Broncos 2022 — Ejiro Evero and the trusted corner

Ejiro Evero, a safeties and secondary coach on the Rams' staff through 2021, became Denver's defensive coordinator in 2022. The Broncos went 5–12 that season, but not because of the defense: it finished seventh in the NFL in total defense (320 yards a game) and third in net yards per pass attempt (5.6).¹⁵ In the nflverse charting the 2022 Broncos played quarters or Cover 6 on 33.3% of dropbacks, sixth in the league (the league rate was 24.8%), and their second-year cornerback Patrick Surtain II was named first-team All-Pro.¹⁶ Evero has run Carolina's defense since 2023.

What to notice: this is the place to watch the corner rules. A corner the defense trusts alone lets it play MEG on one side and lean its safety toward the other, or bracket the other side's best receiver in Cover 6. On a 2022 Broncos passing down, find Surtain first, then the safety on his side. If the safety drifts away from him at the snap, Surtain is on an island by design.

i Film room: Michigan State 2013 — Narduzzi's quarters

The college reference point. Michigan State's 2013 defense, coordinated by Pat Narduzzi, led the nation in total defense through the regular season (248.2 yards a game) and ranked third in scoring defense (11.3 points a game), and Narduzzi won the Broyles Award as the top assistant in college football. Cornerback Darqueze Dennard won the Thorpe Award as the nation's best defensive back. The defense was a 4-3 with quarters behind it: two safeties at 8 to 10 yards reading #2 and fitting the run, and corners who played their receivers aggressively, so aggressively that Narduzzi admitted his quarters "can look like man a lot of the time."¹⁷

What to notice: if you find 2013 Michigan State film, count the run defenders on a running play one second after the snap. Seven start near the line; within a second there are often nine, as both safeties arrive. On passes, watch the corners press and carry receivers deep: MOD from press, which is why it looks like man.

¹⁵Carolina Panthers, "Five things to know about new defensive coordinator Ejiro Evero" (Feb. 5, 2023): <https://www.panthers.com/news/five-things-to-know-about-new-defensive-coordinator-ejiro-evero> (2022 Broncos "seventh" in total defense at 320 yards a game and "third-best in net yards per passing attempt (5.6)"; five years with the Rams coaching safeties and the secondary, and their 2021 defensive passing game coordinator).

¹⁶Denver Broncos, "Pat Surtain II named an AP first-team All-Pro; Justin Simmons selected to second team" (Jan. 2023): <https://www.denverbroncos.com/news/pat-surtain-ii-named-an-ap-first-team-all-pro-justin-simmons-selected-to-second->. Coverage shares: course calculation as in the note on the 2020 Rams, 2022 season: Broncos 15.6% COVER_4 and 17.7% COVER_6 (n = 603), sixth in the league; league 24.8%; the Jets led at 45.5%.

¹⁷FootballScoop account of Narduzzi's 2014 clinic talk, cited in full in the note on Roethlisberger: "Narduzzi admitted his coverage can look like man a lot of the time."

💡 Watch for it on Sunday: two-high, now what?

When the defense shows two deep safeties, don't stop at "two-high." Use the next three looks.

- **Before the snap: depth and width.** Safeties at 12 to 14 yards, outside the hashes: think Cover 2 or a half-field player. Safeties at 8 to 10 yards over the slot or the tight end: think quarters. One deep and wide, one shallow and inside: think Cover 6, with the half on the deep safety's side. Then the corners: both off 7 or 8 yards, eyes on their receivers, suggests quarters; one squatting at 5 with outside leverage suggests a Cover 2 half; one shallow and inside with his eyes on the slot suggests Palms.
- **At the snap: the safeties' first steps.** Watch one safety for one second. *Backpedal* or turn and run for the sideline: a half-field player (Cover 2, or the Cover 2 side of Cover 6). *Downhill* toward the line: a quarters safety reading run, or a called rotation (the other safety will tell you which: if he runs to the middle, it's a rotation to one-high). *Flat-footed, then with #2 up the seam*: quarters, carrying #2.
- **One second later: the corners.** Both bailing with eyes on the quarterback: quarters. Both squatting: Cover 2. One of each: Cover 6. A corner coming *forward* toward the slot's out route while the safety on that side runs deep and wide over the outside receiver: Palms.
- **Then watch the ball.** On runs, find the first defender to the ball. If it's a safety arriving three to five yards downfield, you've just watched quarters' run fit. On passes, note whether the completion was short and outside (what quarters concedes) or deep (what it exists to stop).

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play 1: the shallow safeties

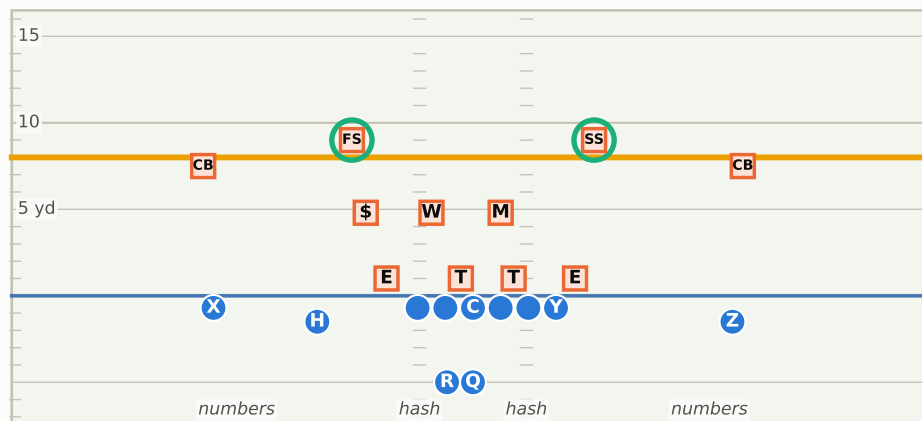


Figure 11: Second-and-8 from the offense's 40. 11 personnel, 2x2, tight end attached on the right. Both safeties (ringed) are 9 yards deep, a couple of yards inside the slot and the tight end. Both corners are 7 to 8 yards off. Six defenders in the box against six blockers. Use the depth numbers and the hash marks.

What coverage family is this most likely to be, and if you were calling plays, which run and which pass would you like against it?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: the halves disagree

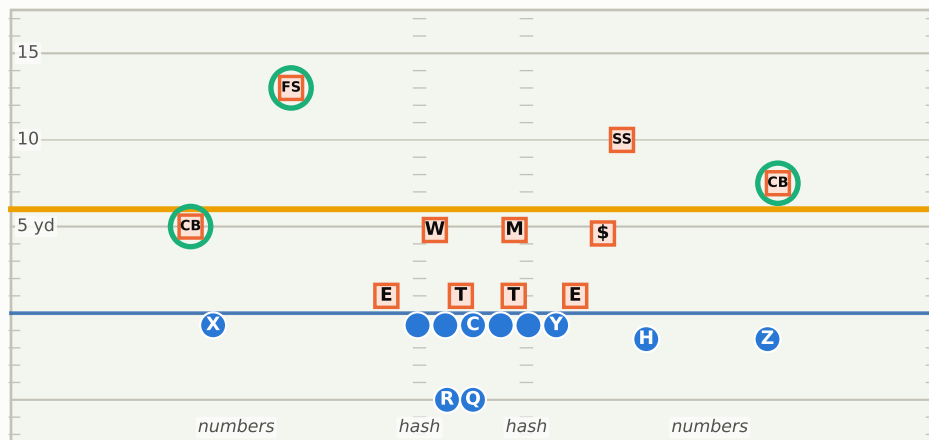


Figure 12: Third-and-6. Trips to the offense's right (Z, H and the attached tight end Y), X alone on the left. Two-high. Compare the two halves: the left corner is 5 yards off X with outside leverage, and the left safety is 13 yards deep, between the hash and the numbers. On the right, the corner is 7 to 8 yards off and the safety about 10 yards deep, inside H. The three defenders to compare are ringed.

What is the coverage likely to be? The offense's best receiver is X. Should the quarterback throw to him?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: the corner who isn't looking at his man

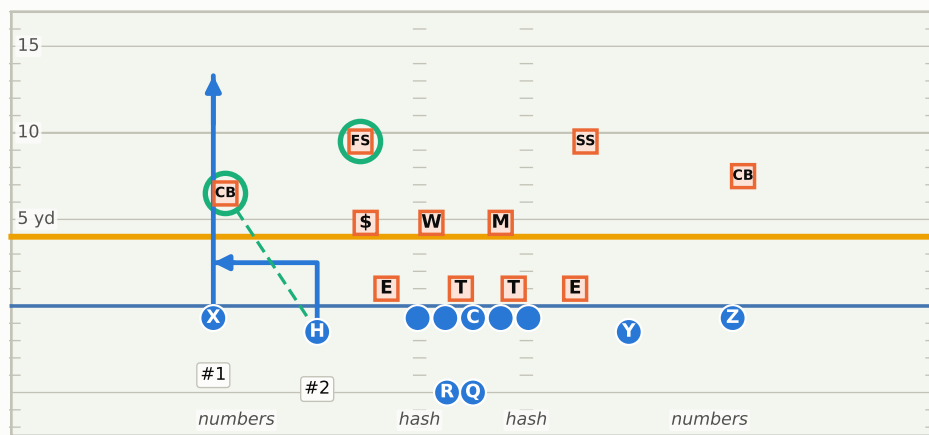


Figure 13: Second-and-4 from the offense's 30. The play call: H (#2) runs a quick out at 4 yards, X (#1) runs a go route to clear the corner out (both routes drawn). The defense looks like quarters, but the left corner (ringed) is 6 to 7 yards deep, a little inside X, and the green dashed line shows where his eyes are: on H. The free safety is ringed too.

The quarterback sees an off corner and thinks the quick out to H is free. What is the danger, and what would you call the next time you see this corner?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- **Quarters is a read coverage, not four deep zones.** Corners and safeties start with deep quarters, but the receivers' releases decide who covers whom: the corner takes #1 deep (MOD), the safety reads #2. It is the purest pattern-matching coverage in common use.
- **The read safety is the whole design.** One key, #2, gives three answers: carry him if he goes vertical, bracket #1 if he goes out or short, fill the alley if he blocks. Standing 8 to 10 yards deep lets one player be a deep defender and a run defender on the same snap.
- **MOD and MEG are a trade between help and freedom.** MOD lets short routes go to the underneath defenders and doubles the deep ones; MEG locks a trusted corner on his man and frees his teammates for other jobs.
- **Cover 6 and Palms fix quarters' soft spots without adding a player.** Cover 6 puts a Cover 2 half on the lone receiver (under-over on him) and quarters on the trips side; Palms swaps the corner and safety so the corner can trap #2's quick out.
- **Two-high match spread because it stops explosive passes without surrendering the run, answers spread passing concepts, and disguises well.** Split-safety coverage rose from 32.9% of dropbacks in 2018 to 42.0% in 2025 by NGS's count; the charting data agree on the total but split it differently across the 2022/2023 source break.
- **Its holes follow from its rules:** light-box runs when receivers take the safeties away, the bootleg flood that turns the safeties' run read against them, and the wheel that changes from a flat route to a deep one after the rules have assigned it.

Connections

Builds on: Coverage Fundamentals (deep quarters, pattern matching and the numbering dialects), Cover 3 (match rules and MEG in Cover 3), Cover 2 and Tampa 2 (the half-field safety and squat corner that Cover 6 borrows), and Run Fits and Box Math (the alley player, the plus-one and the light box).

Sets up: Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage, which starts from the two-high shell built here and shows how it changes at the snap, the trips checks (poach, solo, stubbie) and Saban's Cover 7; Concepts Versus Coverages, the offense's menu against quarters; The College Laboratory, where split-field quarters grew up against the spread; The Modern Era, on the two-high wave and the offenses' heavy-personnel answer; and Tendencies, PROE and Charting, which works with the coverage labels charted above.

Case study: Fangio's Two-High Revolution and Macdonald's Answer follows the two-high family through the NFL's most influential two-high coordinator and the defense built to beat the offenses that adapted to it.

Go deeper

- Cody Alexander, *Match Quarters: A Modern Guidebook to Split-Field Coverages*, and his MatchQuarters newsletter: the most thorough public treatment of quarters, Cover 6 and Palms from a coach's point of view.
- Cameron Soran, "The Complete Guide to Nick Saban Coverages at Alabama," Throw Deep Publishing (2021): MOD, MEG, Palms, Stubbie and Cover 7, rule by rule.
- Chris B. Brown, *The Art of Smart Football* (2015) and his Grantland piece on Gary Patterson's TCU defense: the best short introductions to why quarters took over college football.
- X&O Labs' clinic-style reports on two-high coverage structures, and Pat Narduzzi's Cover 4 clinic talks, for the run-fit side.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

Quarters, or something that will look like it for a beat. Two safeties at 9 yards, inside the receivers on their side, are reading safeties, not half-field players: a Cover 2 safety would be at 12 to 14 and outside the hash, because he has to reach the sideline. Off corners on both sides fit quarters' MOD rule. (A defense can still rotate out of this at the snap; the depth makes a buzz or robber rotation easy, as Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage shows.)

The run: the box is six against six, but the safeties are the extra fitters. So run the ball *away* from the tight end, toward the slot side, and have the slot receiver (H) release up the field so the free safety has to go with him: that takes one fitter out. Or call an RPO that reads the safety: hand off if he stays deep, throw behind him if he comes down.

The pass: quarters gives up quick outside throws, so a quick out or flat route by #2 is there, unless the corner is playing Palms on that side. Deeper, attack the safety's read: play-action with a deep crosser (the safety steps up on the run fake), or a route

combination that makes the safety and corner cross, such as scissors (the post by #1, the corner route by #2) from Dropback Concepts. Four verticals is the one call this defense was built for.

Answer 2.

Most likely Cover 6, with the Cover 2 half on X. The left side is a Cover 2 picture: a squat corner (5 yards, outside leverage, ready to take the flat and the quick out) and a deep, wide safety who can reach the sideline over the top. The right side is a quarters picture: an off corner and a shallower safety inside #2. Two halves, two coverages.

Probably not to X. The offense put its best receiver alone to get him one-on-one, and Cover 6 is built to deny exactly that: X has a corner underneath and a safety over the top. A hitch or quick out runs into the squat corner; a go route runs into the half-field safety. The one window on that side is the Cover 2 hole shot, the sideline between the corner and the safety, 18 to 22 yards deep, and it needs a perfect throw.

Throw to the trips side instead, where four defenders cover three receivers. The pressure point is #3: send the tight end straight up the middle with H up the seam beside him, and the strong safety can carry only one of them; the other is the Mike's, a linebacker running with a receiver down the field.

Answer 3.

The danger is Palms: the trap. A corner who lines up a little shallower than usual, inside his receiver, with his eyes on the slot, is reading #2. When H breaks out, the corner leaves X and drives forward on the out, and the free safety, seeing #2 go out, takes X deep. X's go route was supposed to clear the corner away; instead it runs into the safety, and the quick out is thrown into a defender coming downhill. Best case for the offense, an incompleteness; worst case, an interception returned the other way.

Next time, bait the trap. Call an out-and-up for H (or a wheel): the same first 4 yards, then up the sideline behind the jumping corner, with the safety busy with X. Or attack the moment the corner looks inside: a quick slant by X, inside a corner whose eyes are on H. The deeper lesson is the trade every match rule makes. Palms takes away the quick out, and in doing so tells you which route will beat it.